

A FOGBOUND STORY



NESTED DOLLS



SOME THINGS ARE
HIDDEN FOR A REASON.

Entry 0- Ben's Story

Entry 1. Nested Dolls 🪸

Entry 2. 18:21



It was a long ride out.

Nothing around but half-dead trees, glassy sky, and that low buzz of night insects starting up for the shift. Horse's hooves made that familiar beat, like a lazy drum line, dragging us toward something we already didn't want to do.

Kelly had a matchstick in his mouth again. He didn't light it. Just worked it between his teeth like it was helping him think.

He said, "You believe in heaven?"

I shifted in my saddle, squinting ahead like I was lookin' for something through the dark.

"You askin' 'cause you're scared, or 'cause you're bored?"

"Damn," he laughed. "Can't a brotha wonder without gettin' psychoanalyzed?"

“You’re wonderin’ a little loud, is all.”

His eyes followed a vulture flying by.

“Nah,” he said. “Just thinkin’. Maybe it’s all these bodies we been leavin’ behind.

Kinda makes a man wonder what happens to ‘em.”

He flicked the reins. “Well? You do, or not?”

I let the silence hang.

It wasn’t the easiest question to answer, given all that we’d seen and done.

“...Yeah,” I said eventually. “Think I do.”

Kelly gave me a side glance, grinning around his matchstick. “Like the 77 virgins kind, or the harp music and all the saints singin’?”

“Nah.”

“White beard, man in the sky?”

“Nope.”

He nodded slow. “Then what?”

“I don’t think the idea’s wrong, just think folks got the details twisted.”

“Exactly. There’s gotta be more than 77 of ‘em, right? If heaven is forever and all—”

He paused as I glanced at him, plainly.

“Ok, ok. Well, what *do* you believe?”

I paused for a second, catching the cool of an unexpected breeze.

“I think it’s up.”

Horse grunted.

“Up?” Kelly said. “The hell you mean by that?”

“I’m...” I parted my mouth to speak as another breeze swept by, gently touching Horse’s mane.“

—Looking for the right words, right?”

Exactly.

I looked for a second. Not too long from now the sun would be gone.

“Not sky up. Just... higher. Like layers.”

“Layers?”

“Nesting dolls, y’know?”

“You tellin’ me we livin’ inside of a damn doll?” He joked.

I smiled a little.

“I’m sayin’ maybe there’s stuff outside of us we ain’t built to perceive. Doesn’t mean it ain’t there.”

Kelly spat the matchstick into the dirt.

“God damn. You gettin’ poetic on me. Next thing you’ll be tellin’ me ghosts live in our boots.”

“Wouldn’t be the weirdest thing we’ve seen.”

He paused. “Well that’s... something.”

“Could be worse.”

He leaned back in the saddle.

“Ah’ight, I’ll bite. So what happens when you die? You just get cracked open and what, pop into the next one?”

“Maybe. Maybe we’ve already popped into this one, and we just forgot.”

Kelly gave me a look like I’d told him I was secretly a fish.

“You been eatin’ them weird mushrooms again?”

“Weren’t you the one who snuck ‘em in the pot last time?”

We laughed.

“Well me, I think it’s just light.”

“Not a person, not a place. Not even the virgins, J.”

He watched the horizon for a while.

“Just light. Warm, clean, and gone.”

The thought was nice.

Faces I’d spent years trying to forget crossed my mind as I watched the last bit of sun disappear behind the trees.

“I’d like that.”

We didn’t talk for a while after that.

The house was slumped on a patch of red dirt like it knew it shouldn't be there.

Porch was cracked, shutters danglin', and chimney leanin' like it'd just left a saloon.

We left the horses at the tree line as we watched it for a minute. Horse nipped at me before we finally left, almost like she was reminding me to be careful.

I could feel Kelly watching me as I pulled out the paper we'd gotten from a kill a while back... our first. No good looking at it now, but still; We'd be going to *that place* soon.

“Think they know we're here?” Kelly said as we neared the door.

“I'd be surprised if they didn't.”

I twisted the knob. No resistance.

We stepped inside to what smelled like blood and burnt sugar.

Two women were waiting. Sisters. You could tell from the ugly jawlines and the way they shared a glance without speakin'. One of 'em was sewing a doll's face out of old leather. She was tall and thin, wearing a shirt with the word "Baddie" stitched into the sleeve. The other, a little shorter, a little bigger, stirred something in a pot—bone clinking against the metal.

"Well now," the pot one said, not lookin' up. "Look what the night dragged in."

"We got guests?" the "Baddie" one grinned. "I didn't sweep."

Kelly raised his revolver. "Aww it's fine. We won't be long."

She grinned wider— a crooked grin that quickly turned into anger. “Bitches!”

They came at us— hard and laughing.

The first one moved like a shadow that knew exactly where you were gonna step before you did.

A dash to the left.

A feint to the right.

That was all it took for her to avoid Kelly’s knife as he swiped for the throat, missing. Her footwork was surprising.

A switch of her legs and she was behind him, arm around his neck. She smiled as she licked him.

“We gone take ya bodies and make love to ‘em when we done killin’ ya. Get us a few more ingredients for the pot.”

“Love!?” My witch spit. I was surprised the stench of it didn’t burn a hole in the floor.

“Ain’t gonna be no ‘love’ going on.” She tilted her head towards the ceiling as she finished speaking.

The walls seemed to creak as the nastiest noises gathered in her throat.

I shuddered.

She spit.

It barely missed me as I jumped to my left. Where it landed, a quarter sized hole burned into the floor; *there it was*.

Kelly grunted slightly as he reached around, skillfully shooting his witch through the lung and slinging her off his back.

“Marie...” she cried faintly, desperately.

“Bee!” My witch cried.

She jumped away, using the wooden beam near her as cover as she began whispering strange, hissing sounds. She wasn’t as quick as her sister. I was right on her.

The hisses of her whispering grew louder, turning the air sharp– sharp like needles– as she fixed her gaze to Kelly. The room temperature shot up as wind began lifting bits of dirt and clinking bottles together from a nearby wall.

Outside I could hear Horse and Kelly’s horse kicking and having a fit. But the strangest reaction was Kelly. He hadn’t moved. His eyes were fixed forward.

As quickly as I could, I reached for my revolver and shot Marie in the mouth mid-spell, I think...

She hit the ground with a sound like wet wood snapping as the sharpness of the air died down slowly.

No noises from the horses, no sharp air, nothing— except for a faint heat coming from my revolver.

A second later, Marie's blood began crawling across the floor towards her sister like it had its own plans.

I stepped on it.

Kelly shot Bee's, or Baddie's, or whatever her name was, lifeless body in the head; No more room for surprises.

Things were quiet now. Real quiet.

Kelly stood there breathing hard with blood running down his cheek where he'd been licked.

His gun smoked like it was thinking about what just happened. His eyes fixed momentarily on the old time clock on the wall. Actually, more than momentarily...

“Kelly! You ah’ight?”

“Yea, Yea,” He said, as if shaking himself from a daze.

“And what the hell is a ‘Baddie’ anyway?” he mocked partly as he looked down at the sister’s body.

Exactly.

“Gotta be a name right?” I said as my heartbeat slowly began to calm.

“Nah you heard your witch call her ‘Bee’. Can’t be ‘Bee’ and ‘Baddie’. Witches don’t work like that, J.”

“Why not? I mean I’m J and J—”

—Then...

Tap.

A soft sound, not far from the hearth.

Kelly turned towards it, crouching as he pulled up a loose board.

Two kids...

Girl had to be about 8 or 9.

Little boy, maybe six, curled behind her like she was a wall.

He was cryin'. The girl wasn't.

Her eyes were open too wide. They weren't scared. They weren't blank. They were watching.

Kelly stood up slowly. He looked at me, then back down. He raised his revolver.

My mind drifted to the paper from our first kill.

“You sure you wanna do this?” I asked, quiet. “This part... ain’t our weight to carry.”

He didn’t look at me.

“Look at the hate in that one’s eyes, J”, he said. “She’ll come for us one day if we don’t put her down now.”

I looked at the girl. Her hands were shaking, but her jaw was locked tight.

“Yeah,” I said. “She might...”

We rode back.

It was quiet for a long time– other than the sound of horse hooves and thudding sacs that dragged behind us.

Even the wind seemed like it knew better than to speak.

Kelly didn't have his matchstick anymore. He just kept his eyes on the horizon.

“Nested dolls, huh?”

“Nested dolls....”



Entry 0- Ben's Story

Entry 1. Nested Dolls 🪄

Entry 2. 18:21 🕒



Some time after “Nested Dolls”...

An excerpt from “18:21”.

18:21

So did I.

“Sorry to disappoint you, man, but I ain’t here for that. Didn’t think you were either,” I paused before finally deciding to finish my thought.

“least that’s not what you said.”

The look in Kelly’s eyes turned cold. His hand inched closer to his hip. His back straightened.

“You doubting me?”

Instinctively my hand drifted as well. There it was again— that ghost feeling. “Not doubtin’, just remindin’.”

The tone in his voice turned slow and methodical as he stood. Bits of dirt raced quickly from his lap to the ground.

“Well, let me remind you. Just because we’re helping, don’t mean you’re our leader.”

He was right, but as I watched his calloused fingers writhe around the hilt of his revolver I didn't really give a damn.

“What's your hand reachin' for, Kelly?” I asked as I stood to meet his glance.

“You gonna challenge me? We both know how that's gonna turn out.”

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